

EASTERN SPARKS (BOOK 2)

Chapter 5: What the Heat Asks For

Sofia Vale · Bangkok, Thailand — Silom / Lumpini Park / Côte-style restaurant / Chao Phraya

Bangkok didn't let you arrive quietly.

Suvarnabhumi gave you the controlled part — enormous, modern, organized, signage in English, an arrivals hall that could have belonged to a dozen other airports except for the smell. That was the tell. By the time she cleared customs, the air-conditioning's antiseptic chill had thinned enough at the edges that she could already feel the city pressing against it from the other side: warmer, heavier, carrying something green and fermented and alive. She stood at the exit and thought: *Tokyo held itself back. This one is already talking.*

She got in the taxi and the city told her the rest of the story.

The expressway south was elevated, which gave Bangkok a perspective Florence and Barcelona had never offered: the whole sprawl visible at once, not the compressed medieval heart of a European city but something vast and continuous, the grid interrupted by highway intersections and the occasional green explosion of a temple roof, gold visible even from this height. The driver had the radio on — not Thai pop, as it turned out, but something older, a kind of music she couldn't locate precisely, melodic and slightly melancholy in the way that music is melancholy when it has been played in a specific place for generations. It suited the city better than she expected.

Her apartment was near Silom — a compact serviced room, familiar architecture of the kind of place built for people who would be there for months, not years. Third floor, a window overlooking a side street where a spirit house on the corner had been freshly garlanded with marigolds the color of turmeric. She unpacked in the order she'd learned: uniform first, pressed and hung; notebook on the desk; running shoes visible by the door, because if the shoes required searching for she would not use them. Small habits for a life in motion. Her avó's apartment in São Paulo had known exactly where everything was. There was a version of order that had nothing to do with permanence.

She pressed her shirt. She looked out the window at the marigolds.

A different city. The same floor.

She slept.

She found Lumpini Park at five-forty-five on her second morning, following the sound of birdsong that seemed improbably loud for the center of a city of this density. The park earned it: trees large enough to have been there before the towers, the canopy so complete in places that the sky appeared in fragments between branches, and at this hour the light arriving in the long tropical columns that made sense only at latitudes where the sun rose purposefully, with intention.

She ran the outer circuit and let Bangkok heat instruct her.

This was not Florence's companionable warmth or Barcelona's dry afternoon fire. This was a different physical fact entirely — the air not just warm but present, the humidity giving the air a weight she could feel against her forearms and her lungs, a running partner she hadn't asked for. By the second kilometer she'd adjusted her pace downward without deciding to. Not defeat. Recalibration. You ran this park at the park's speed, not yours.

On the northern path she passed a man running the opposite way — tall, measured stride, the kind of form that suggested he'd been running cities for years and had made his peace with pavement. She didn't look at him. She was watching the treeline to her left, where one of the monitor lizards had crossed the path ahead with the calm authority of something that had been navigating this park since before the concept of inconveniencing anyone. She'd been warned about them, by Arno in their first planning message. *They don't care about you*, he'd said. She'd found this enormously appealing as a statement.

She ran past the lake, past the pedal boats still tied and motionless in the early light, past a group of older women doing a choreographed exercise routine to a song that appeared to be a Thai adaptation of something Western and cheerful. She added a third circuit, because the park asked for it and she was not yet tired in the way that mattered.

By the time she returned to the Silom side and stretched in the park's shadow, the marigolds on the spirit house next to her building were already lit — someone had relit the small candle, which seemed early, and the smoke went straight up in the still pre-dawn air without deviation.

She stood watching it for a moment.

What the room teaches you, you carry. She'd written that on the plane. She could feel Tokyo behind her — the compression and the silence, the maple in the slot of sky, Matsuda-san's two fingers on the counter's edge. She could feel it the way you feel a place you've been fluent in: it was now part of the register she spoke, not a lesson she was visiting. Bangkok was adding a new language on top of the first one, and the question was how the two would sit together.

She showered. She ate a congee from the shop at the end of the block, standing, because the shop had nowhere to sit and didn't seem interested in acquiring any. The congee was smooth and deeply savory and flavored with something she couldn't fully identify — ginger, certainly, and a dried something, and a quality of time that meant whoever made it had been doing exactly this long enough to stop thinking about it. She stood in the street eating it and the city went about its morning.

She was already learning to like this city.

The restaurant was on a side street off Silom, set back from the main road behind a walled garden where a single frangipani tree grew in the corner with the complete self-sufficiency of something that had been there longer than the building. The interior was pale: white walls, linen, brass-fixture low lighting, the kind of space that was spare without being cold. The kitchen ran French technique — stock-based, classical in its saucing architecture, precise in its timing and mise en place. But the menu had been written for Bangkok: aromatic broths that carried lemongrass and galangal inside a consommé frame, duck prepared with a tamarind reduction that was European in method and entirely Thai in character. The kitchen understood what it was trying to be, which was rarer than it should have been.

The floor manager was Arno — French-trained, Thai-based, the man who had reached out to Yamamoto through the industry back channels. He was forty, practical, with the brisk warmth of someone who had loved hospitality long enough that the love had become structural rather than performed. He showed her the floor in the first afternoon the way Yamamoto had shown her the Ginza floor: methodically, without excess commentary, expecting her to absorb rather than to ask.

What she noticed: the room ran warmer than anything in Tokyo. Not the temperature — the register. Guests arrived already slightly open, slightly expansive, the Bangkok evening heat having done something to the formality they'd carried into the day. European guests brought a specific relaxation that the climate produced in people not used to it. Thai guests brought a quality of social ease that operated horizontally — everyone at the table equal in warmth, the hierarchy present but expressed through attention rather than formality.

The veteran server was a woman named Khun Fon — fifty-two, twenty years on the floor, the kind of professional whose competence was invisible from the dining room and entirely legible to anyone who had worked beside her for ten minutes. She moved through the tables with the unhurried efficiency of someone who had long since stopped managing the room and simply occupied it. She taught Sofia the floor not by instruction but by proximity — stand here, not there;

approach from this side at this course; the table near the window seats four but thinks of itself as two, so serve it in pairs.

Sofia absorbed this. She recognized the teaching style.

On her third shift, during a quiet second seating, Khun Fon stopped beside her at the pass and said — in English with a considered, formal quality: "The room here is happy before it sits down. Your job is not to create the warmth. It already has warmth. Your job is to keep it honest."

Sofia turned this over for the rest of the evening.

Keep it honest. In Tokyo, warmth had been a secondary register, something you offered only after the room had given you reason to open toward it. Here, warmth was already present and yours was to match it without performing it — to be genuinely, specifically present inside the table's happiness rather than decorating it from the outside. If Tokyo had taught her silence as a quality of attention, Bangkok was teaching her warmth as the same thing.

Two cities. Two frequencies. The same instrument.

The birthday table arrived on her sixth shift.

A couple — Thai, late thirties, clearly not regulars at this kind of restaurant, clearly here because tonight was meaningful. The woman had dressed carefully: the attention in the clothes suggested this was not a frequent occasion. The man had reserved a full week in advance, per the booking notes, which at this particular restaurant meant he had done his research. The VIP notation was brief: *wife's birthday. First visit.*

Sofia read it three times.

The difference between a birthday table that became a story they'd tell afterward and one that merely passed pleasantly was almost never the food. It was the sequence of small signals the table sent and whether the floor received them or missed them. The woman's careful clothes. The man's early arrival to approve the table. These were not background details. They were the brief.

She cleared the note and went to pre-position the table: she moved a candle two centimeters closer to the center, which changed the lighting fall in a way that was minor and intentional. She confirmed with the kitchen that the chef's amuse-bouche could be presented with a single orchid from the bar's arrangement, which the kitchen confirmed with a nod. Small things. The table didn't know she'd done any of it. That was the point.

When the couple arrived, Sofia greeted them by the woman's name — from the booking, which she'd memorized exactly as she would have memorized the dietary modifier for a VIP. *Khun Arunee*. Not *the birthday guest*. Her name.

The woman's expression changed. Not dramatically — just the small shift that happens when a person realizes they are being received rather than processed.

They sat. Sofia left them to themselves for the first minutes — let the room and the candlelight and the occasion do the work that it was already doing without her. Then the first course arrived, and she described it briefly: what the kitchen had made, why it sat the way it did in its vessel, the balance of the tamarind against the reduction. She spoke to both of them equally. She did not single out the birthday, which could tip from warmth into performance. She let them inhabit the occasion.

Between the second and third courses, she brought the wine list.

The man glanced at it and looked slightly at sea — not embarrassed, just at the outer edge of his knowledge. She didn't let him stall there. She said: "If I can suggest — we have a rosé from Languedoc that's been excellent with the third course this week. It's dry, not sweet, and it'll lift what's coming from the kitchen rather than compete with it." She named the price. She put it in front of the information and stepped back.

He looked at her. "That sounds right."

She poured it when the third course arrived. She didn't ceremony it — she poured it cleanly, confirmed by the glass, moved on. The man tasted it. Then he tasted the course. Then he looked across the table at his wife with an expression that was private and uncomplicated and fully his.

Sofia was already at the next table. She'd seen what she needed to see.

She had learned, in the first week, the geography of the street-food Bangkok that coexisted beside the linen-and-lacquer Bangkok in a way that neither absorbed nor competed with the other. They were simply two truths about the same city, running in parallel.

Arno had given her the general orientation, with the economy of a person who had given it many times before: "Eat on Silom Road on your way home. Eat around the clock tower in Chinatown when you have the night off. Don't eat cautiously — that's its own waste." He said it without looking up from his prep notes, which was how he delivered information he considered fundamental.

She had followed the instruction with seriousness.

The pad thai on the corner of her block was made by a woman who worked a single wok with a spatula so practiced the metal had worn to a polish at the edge. The cooking happened fast — faster than restaurant service, the heat higher, the timing measured in seconds rather than minutes — and the result was not a restaurant version of pad thai but the thing itself: the noodles at exactly the right give, the egg cooked directly into them without losing its identity, the dried shrimp present without dominating, the lime a correct small tightening. She ate it standing at the cart's edge three nights in a row and the woman began handing it to her before she'd finished pointing.

Memory as service, she wrote in her notebook, by her bedside, at midnight. *The woman at the cart doesn't remember me specifically. She remembers the noodle order. The recognition lives in the food.*

She crossed it out. Added: *Maybe she does remember. I don't know. Either way the result is the same.*

Boat noodles. She found the cart on a parallel street at Keiko's recommendation, via a voice message from Tokyo that had arrived with a Google Maps pin and the words: *don't skip the pork blood, I know how that sounds*. The broth was dark and deep in a way that had nothing to do with French technique and everything to do with time and accumulated purpose — the kind of broth that was the product of someone deciding, repeatedly, across decades, that the only acceptable outcome was this exact thing.

She sat on the low stool in the heat and ate it and thought about the kaiseki kitchen in Ginza, the dashi shifting week to week as the season moved, the kinmedai firmer-fleshed than its predecessor. Different methods. The same intention: the thing at its best, arrived at through knowing it completely.

She ate everything Arno had told her to eat, and some things he hadn't.

The Chao Phraya on a night off was Arno's other instruction, delivered as a statement rather than a suggestion: *Walk the river when you don't have to be anywhere*. He'd said it twice in three days, which she took to mean it was important.

She walked south from Charoenkrung on a Tuesday when the restaurant was dark, the evening still warm past nine o'clock, the city doing its continuous thing in every direction. The river path opened at a gap between two riverside hotels: old teak buildings set back from the bank, their facades hung

with small lights that reflected in the water below. The tourist boats had finished their runs. The working boats hadn't — a long-tail cut upriver in a rush of exhaust and noise, its wake spreading across the dark surface in arcs that took their time reaching the bank.

She walked south. The city's noise organized itself with distance — not quieter, just more layered, each sound taking its correct position in the overall composition the way a proper dish organized its flavors into a single impression rather than a series of interruptions. She passed a spirit house at the river's edge, candle lit, fresh jasmine lei around the figure inside. A group of students sat on the lower step, not talking, looking at the water. A delivery motorbike navigated the narrow path behind her at a polite crawl.

A figure ahead: walking north, toward her. Tall, unhurried, a quality of movement she would have identified anywhere as someone who spent their working hours in closed spaces and was using the outdoors for the specific decompression that outdoor movement offered. Dark jacket, hands loose. Under his left arm, or perhaps in his left hand, something rectangular — a notebook, or what looked like one, carried not tucked or hidden but simply present, the way a person carries something they've stopped noticing the weight of.

She noted this with the professional attention that was now simply attention — the server's eye, reading a room even when the room was a riverside path at ten past nine. *Server*, she thought, with the certainty that two years of floors gave you. *Or kitchen. Someone who works.*

They were perhaps thirty meters apart. She was looking at the river. He was looking — she thought, from the angle of his head, though she couldn't see his face clearly in the variable light — somewhere ahead and slightly upward, the way people look when they're thinking rather than looking.

Twenty meters. She stepped slightly to the right to give him the path's center. He adjusted at the same time, the small automatic correction of someone used to managing space in tight corridors. They passed without speaking. She heard, for a half-second, the sound of a page — maybe the notebook being closed, or maybe nothing, the sound was so brief — and then he was past her and the path was empty ahead.

She walked on.

Precise, she thought, without examining why. And then the thought dissolved into the sound of the next long-tail boat going upriver and the city took her attention back.

She didn't look behind her.

She walked until the path ended at a terrace bar she didn't feel like entering and then stood at the rail above the water for a while, the city on the opposite bank reflected imperfectly — shifting with each passing boat, reforming when the surface calmed. She thought about the anniversary table, about Khun Fon's *keep it honest*, about Matsuda-san's two fingers on the counter's edge and how they were saying the same thing in different registers. She thought about Keiko's voice message, the pragmatic warmth of it, which had sounded like Keiko sounded in a bar after a clean service: real and unguarded and completely herself.

Find the people who are completely themselves, she wrote later in the notebook. *They're the ones who teach you without intending to.*

She walked back along the river. The path was emptier now. The tall figure was gone. She took the Silom bridge back to her side of the city, the river black below and very wide.

The invitation arrived from Arno, not as an invitation exactly but as a statement that there was a thing happening on Thursday if she was interested. A group — industry contacts, floor people from a few different restaurants, some from the French side and some Thai, a couple of others from the international-hotel circuit. Late night, which meant after service. Chinatown, Yaowarat Road. A food crawl, which in Bangkok terminology meant two or three hours of moving between stalls on foot, eating everything available, spending nothing and getting everything.

"You should go," he said, already leaving the kitchen. "You haven't done Chinatown properly yet."

He was right. She'd had the address in her mind since the Bangkok flight — she'd been thinking about Yaowarat Road specifically since before she'd landed, without a clear reason for it, the way you carry an anticipation that doesn't yet have its object. The photographs she'd found: street-side stalls at midnight, the air visibly thick with steam and exhaust and the smell of things cooking in hot oil, plastic stools on pavement, people eating shoulder to shoulder in the heat. She'd looked at them in the Narita departure hall and felt something specific, something that wasn't hunger exactly.

It was the feeling, she understood now, of a place she was supposed to have been to already.

Thursday was two nights away. She put it in her notebook not as a reminder — she wouldn't forget — but as a fact she wanted to make real by writing it down. Some things required the page to confirm they were happening.

She made tea. She stood at the window over the Silom side street, the spirit house visible below, the marigolds replaced today with a fresh lei of jasmine. She'd been watching this routine — the daily

replacement, the candle lit each morning — with a specific respect for it that she hadn't expected and couldn't entirely explain. It was not a superstition she'd grown up with. But the gesture was one she recognized: the daily act of caring for something you couldn't see fully, maintaining the relationship regardless of whether you could prove it was received.

Her avó had done this with food. With the people who ate the food. With the memory of people no longer there to eat it.

Service is also a form of that, she thought. She let herself have the thought without writing it down, because some things were better held.

The city outside was doing its continuous thing — motorbike, the vendor's call two streets over, a temple bell at an interval she hadn't yet established the pattern of. She was beginning to hear it as music rather than noise. That was the difference between arriving in a city and being in one.

She had been in Bangkok for less than a month. She was already in it.

She ran Lumpini the next morning at five-forty again.

The outer circuit, then the inner. The monitor lizard was there on the northern path, different one or the same one — she couldn't tell and the lizard gave no indication that the distinction mattered. The exercise group on the lake side was larger this morning, which may have had to do with weather: the sky had a quality that suggested rain later, the pressure different, the air before a tropical storm having its own specific weight and smell. She ran the second circuit faster than the first, settling into the pace the park allowed.

At the far end of the inner path, in the gap between the canopy and the open sky, she stopped for a moment.

Tokyo was behind her — fully behind her now, in the way a posting becomes the past rather than the present. She could feel the Ginza kitchen and the reservation book and the maple's stillness, and she felt them clearly, and they were no longer urgent. Bangkok was present. The river walk was present. Thursday night was present.

She stood at the end of the path with her hands on her knees and the tropical dawn doing its work around her and thought: *I have been moving toward something for two years*. She didn't know what it was yet. She was good at not knowing what it was — she had, by now, a reasonable trust in the moving-toward part, in the evidence that cities and floors and kitchens and mistakes and recoveries

had been assembling something in her that had not existed when she'd arrived in Florence with a deferred Le Cordon Bleu acceptance and a backpack and the wooden spoon still imprinted in her palm.

She just didn't know what the thing was yet.

Thursday, she thought, and stood back up.

She ran the exit path. The city opened ahead of her beyond the park gates — bright, continuous, already going, the marigolds on the spirit house relit and the congee shop's window fogged. She ran through the park gates and into the street and the traffic noise picked up around her and she kept going, the city parting around her the way it did when you moved with its grain rather than against it.

Two days.

She ran home.

End of Chapter 5